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Presidential Travel from Eisenhower to George W. Bush: An “Electoral College” Strategy

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Since the days of George Washington, the responsibilities of the American president have expanded enormously, so much so that the president is generally considered to be at the apex of the U.S. political system. As a result, presidents must not only be effective at persuading policymakers inside the beltway, but must actively cultivate a personal following across the country—nurturing their base and expanding their appeal across constituencies. Scholars have clearly noted the tendency of presidents to “go public,” bolstering public support via televised speeches, symbolic photo opportunities and, increasingly, travel.¹ Recent research suggests that when Air Force One lands in a state far away from Washington, DC, reporters in that location pay particularly close attention, and coverage of the trip tends to be positive.² While some observers lament the degree to which presidents are relentlessly mobilizing support, little attention has been focused on the dynamics of

¹ George C. Edwards, *The Public Presidency: The Pursuit of Popular Support* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1983); and Samuel Kernell, *Going Public: New Strategies of Presidential Leadership*, 3rd ed. (Washington, DC: Congressional Quarterly Press, 1997), 119–127.

² See, for example, Jeffrey E. Cohen and Richard J. Powell, “Building Public Support from the Grassroots Up: The Impact of Presidential Travel on State-Level Approval,” *Presidential Studies Quarterly* 35 (March 2005): 11–27; and Andrew W. Barrett and Jeffrey S. Peake, “When the President Comes to Town: Examining Local Newspaper Coverage of Domestic Presidential Travel,” *American Politics Research* 35 (January 2007): 3–31.

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presidential travel, and whether this behavior reflects a determined strategy, one sensitive to the demands of the electoral college, and aimed explicitly at a reelection victory.³ We know more about the effects of such trips than what prompts presidential travel in the first place. This article addresses this gap by considering the strategic underpinnings of first-term domestic travel from Dwight D. Eisenhower in 1953 through the end of George W. Bush's first term in office (2004)—a period in which the public responsibilities of the American president grew tremendously.

Since we focus on a president's first term in office, we isolate the entire time frame in which presidents can prepare for their reelection campaign. Acknowledging that the president's time is a finite and invaluable resource, it is well within reason to suspect that White House staff members strategically plan presidential trips to places where they will maximize the positive electoral impact of a presidential visit. In addition to documenting the frequency of presidential travel, we test this supposition by asking whether presidents tend to travel to larger, more competitive states more often than smaller, less-competitive states. (The term "competitive" refers to the president's initial general election performance in that state. This measure is described in greater detail below.) To gauge this strategic element of presidential travel, we provide data on domestic presidential travel to illustrate trends and patterns. Utilizing these data, we move to systematic modeling via regression analysis. As we will show below, presidents appear to act with electoral college-related considerations in mind when they arrange their travel schedules, and this behavior has become far more pronounced among recent presidents.

We begin our analysis with a brief literature review followed by a quantitative analysis of trip taking. We then conclude by briefly discussing the implications of these findings and how we might further contribute to the study of the public presidency.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND: EXPANDING THE BOUNDS OF THE STRATEGIC PRESIDENCY

Though there is much anecdotal evidence that modern presidents are traveling more than their predecessors, we seek to confirm this increase in a systematic way. Two bodies of research prove useful. The first considers the issue of presidential travel by examining presidential activities (e.g., public speeches) and comparisons between foreign and domestic travel.⁴ For example, Lyn Ragsdale

³ See Hugh Heclo, "Campaigning and Governing: A Conspectus" in Norman Ornstein and Thomas Mann, eds., *The Permanent Campaign and Its Future* (Washington, DC: AEI & Brookings Institution, 2000), 1–37; Theodore Lowi, *The Personal President: Power Invested Promise Unfulfilled* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1986); Sidney Blumenthal, *The Permanent Campaign* (New York: Touchstone, 1982).

⁴ Paul Brace and Barbara Hinckley, *Follow the Leader: Opinion Polls and the Modern Presidents* (New York: Basic Books, 1992); William Lammers, "Presidential Attention-Focusing Activities" in

has argued that the decline of parties makes imagery a key aspect of presidential elections and that therefore, “presidents engage in a perpetual campaign of public appearances that consume ever more of their time.”⁵

The second line of relevant research focuses on presidential campaign strategy as it relates to resource allocation. Where will presidential candidates spend their time in order to maximize prospects of reelection? Part of this body of research identifies the electoral college as the primary strategic variable affecting campaign resource allocation.⁶ However, approaches based entirely on population prescribe a universal strategy for presidential campaigns, ignoring potential variations between different candidates. These studies assume that travel patterns should not differ between incumbent and challenger in the same election, and between candidates in different elections within the same census period. As the latter point indicates, such an approach cannot account for increases in presidential travel except through population gains in the census.

Some scholars have also considered the competitiveness of the state as an important factor influencing resource allocation.⁷ While this approach represents an improvement over the population models, data collection is not based on one consistent source, and none of these studies include comparisons across several administrations. Most importantly, rather than examining the entire four-year term, both the population and competitiveness studies consider only a restricted period of time (i.e., the official campaign from Labor Day to Election Day), ignoring the possibility of a more permanent campaign. Further, such studies do not consider the overall amount of travel and whether significant differences emerge across presidents and challengers (either during this “official” campaign period or more generally during a president’s time in office). So while this literature is noteworthy, it is not directly applicable to our line of inquiry. To our knowledge, only Brendan Doherty has sought to trace how reelection considerations shape presidential traveling decisions over the course of an administration. His thoughtful analysis, however, extends only to the Jimmy Carter years. Moreover, Doherty suggests that George W. Bush was less likely than his predecessors to travel to larger states, and that

Doris A. Graber, ed., *The President and the American Public* (Philadelphia, PA: Institute for the Study of Human Issues, 1982), 145–171; Lyn Ragsdale, *Vital Statistics on the Presidency—Washington to Clinton* (Washington, DC: Congressional Quarterly, 1998), 148–184.

⁵ Ragsdale, *Vital Statistics*, 158.

⁶ Larry M. Bartels, “Resource Allocation in a Presidential Campaign,” *The Journal of Politics* 47 (August 1985): 928–936; Steven J. Brahms and Morton D. Davis, “The 3/2’s Rule in Presidential Campaigning,” *The American Political Science Review* 68 (March 1974): 113–134.

⁷ Claude S. Colantoni, Terrence J. Levesque, and Peter C. Ordeshook, “Campaign Resource Allocations under the Electoral College,” *The American Political Science Review* 69 (March 1975): 141–154; Jennifer Merolla, Michael Munger, and Michael Tofias, “In Play: A Commentary on Strategies in the 2004 U.S. Presidential Election,” *Public Choice* 123 (April 2005): 19–37; Daron R. Shaw, “The Methods Behind the Madness: Presidential Electoral College Strategies, 1988–1996,” *The Journal of Politics* 61 (November 1999): 893–913.

Presidents Carter and Ronald Reagan were inclined to visit less-competitive states. As discussed below, our results show very different tendencies for these chief executives.⁸

RESEARCH DESIGN AND DESCRIPTIVE FINDINGS

To determine the frequency of presidential travel, we rely on the successive volumes of the *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*, beginning in 1953 and covering the first terms of Presidents Dwight Eisenhower, Richard Nixon, Jimmy Carter, Ronald Reagan, George H.W. Bush, Bill Clinton, and George W. Bush. The first term would presumably feature more strategic decision making, since presidents have the option of seeking reelection. Due to this important incentive, we limited our study to those presidents who served a complete four-year term and sought another. This annual compilation of presidential speeches and remarks, published by the U.S. Government Printing Office in Washington, DC, records the date and location of these events.⁹

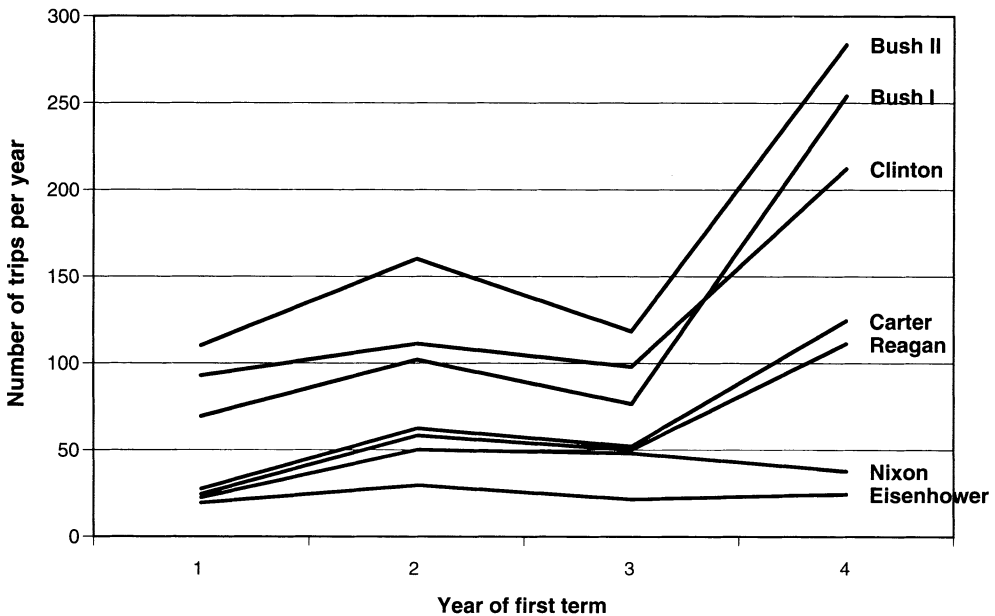
Since we are focused on state travel, we excluded visits in and around Washington, DC, as well as presidential vacations, personal visits (e.g., funerals or trips to private homes), and trips to the presidential retreat at Camp David. We also excluded visits to Maryland and Virginia due to their proximity to Washington, DC and the presence of federal institutions that the president may visit for purely official reasons (e.g., Pentagon, National Institutes of Health). For a trip to be included in our totals, the president would have had to have delivered a speech or a significant set of remarks (not simply a short exchange with reporters). If a president travels to various locations within a state and makes noteworthy statements at these additional locations, we count these trips as multiple trips to that state (even if all trips occur in a single day). Given the variation across states in terms of geographic size, we contend that presidential speeches and remarks in multiple cities clearly represent additional attempts to garner public support and must be counted as separate trips.

In terms of the overall amount of travel undertaken by presidents, this has increased dramatically over the course of the seven administrations under study (see Figure 1). Not only is there a consistent increase from one president to the next (with the exception of Reagan, as discussed below), but there are also interesting patterns within administrations. From Carter onward, there is

⁸ Brendan J. Doherty, "Elections: The Politics of the Permanent Campaign: Presidential Travel and the Electoral College, 1977-2004," *Presidential Studies Quarterly* 37 (December 2007): 749-773, esp. pp. 769-770. See also Brendan J. Doherty, "The Politics of the Permanent Campaign: Presidents, Fundraising and the Electoral College." Ph.D. diss., University of California, Berkeley, 2006, esp. pp. 40, 51-53.

⁹ These data are available on-line for Presidents Clinton and G.W. Bush at www.gpoaccess.gov, accessed on 11 April 2009.

FIGURE 1
Patterns of First-term Trip Totals, Eisenhower to George W. Bush



Source: Travel data drawn from *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*. Washington, DC: United States Government Printing Office.

a consistent pattern of travel across the term, with the first year marking the low point in travel, a peak in the second year coinciding with the midterm elections, a drop in the third year (but not back to Year 1 levels), and then a dramatic upswing in the fourth year, the presidential reelection year.

The only exceptions to this pattern are evident in Reagan's first term, and that of George H.W. Bush (the actual trip totals can be seen in Table 1). In each year of his first term, Reagan traveled slightly less than Carter, while demonstrating the same pattern of election-year peaks, and overall, he took 23 fewer trips. President Reagan's ability to generate support using national television appeals may have obviated the need for local appearances, but his personal preferences may have also played a role: in his 1966 California gubernatorial campaign, Reagan's campaign manager "cut out many needless personal appearances at shopping malls and banquets, partly because Reagan tired and got irritable under a stressful schedule. [He] also recognized that television could replace shaking voters' hands."¹⁰

President George H.W. Bush presents an exception to the general trend in terms of the *scale* of his final year travel. As an overtly public activity, travel is

¹⁰ Blumenthal, *Permanent Campaign*, 173.

TABLE 1
Trip Totals, Yearly, Overall, and Average

<i>President</i>	<i>Year 1</i>	<i>Year 2</i>	<i>Year 3</i>	<i>Year 4</i>	<i>Overall Trips Term 1</i>	<i>Average Trips by Year</i>
Eisenhower	19	30	21	24	94	24
Nixon	22	50	48	38	158	40
Carter	28	62	52	125	267	67
Reagan	25	58	50	111	244	61
Bush I	69	102	77	254	502	126
Clinton	93	111	98	212	514	129
Bush II	110	160	118	284	672	168

Source: Travel data drawn from *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*. Washington, DC: United States Government Printing Office.

an external indicator of the state of a campaign—Bush’s frenetic final-year blitz comports with the popularly perceived image of a president realizing too late the need for direct campaigning. In the long term, the Bush blitz also appears to have raised the overall bar for campaign travel, with Presidents Clinton and then George W. Bush producing much greater average trip totals than the pre-George H.W. Bush presidents.

Not surprisingly, the surges in presidential travel correlate with the midterm and presidential election campaigns. Despite presidential claims of a Rose Garden strategy, where the chief executive tends to stay in or near Washington, DC so as to remain above the campaign fray, the numbers indicate otherwise.¹¹ A presidential visit will always generate extensive local media coverage, and will most likely receive top billing (while the president must compete with other major political actors and events in the national/international press). By physically visiting a location, the president can also geographically target his earned media strategy at a fraction of the cost of local television advertising. But what rationale might a president use to target specific localities?

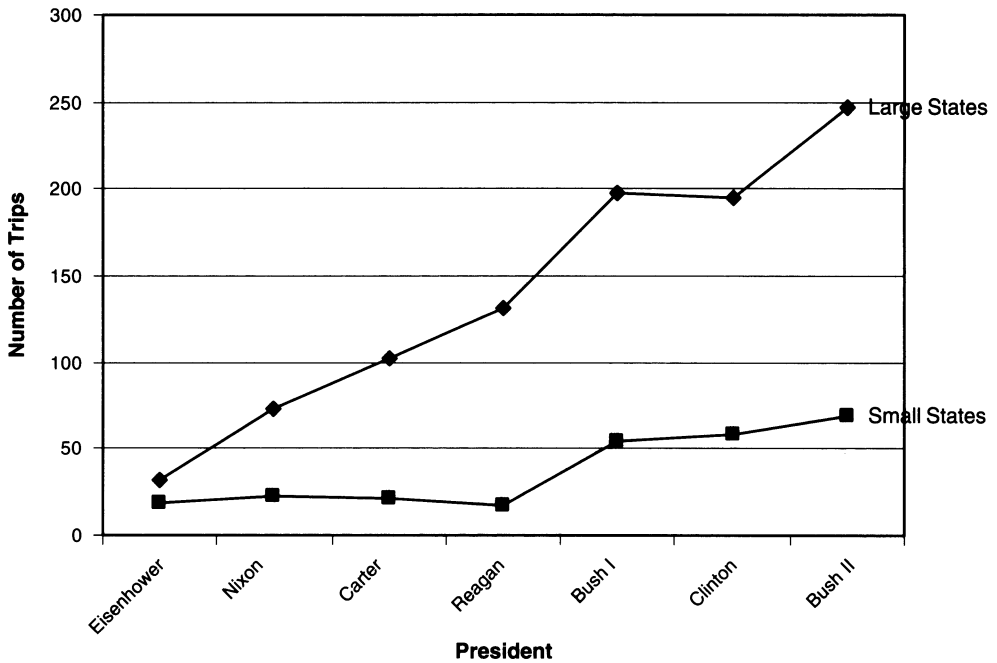
One obvious approach is geared toward the electoral college itself—to target large states, and thereby reap the largest reward in terms of electoral college votes.¹² However, in recent elections, observers have highlighted presidential candidates’ disproportionate attention to “battleground” or “swing” states.¹³ This suggests an alternative presidential travel strategy—visiting the

¹¹ For recent examples of the “Rose Garden strategy,” see Kathryn Dunn Tenpas, *Presidents as Candidates: Inside the White House for the Presidential Campaign* (New York: Routledge, 2003), 46–48.

¹² Stephen J. Wayne, *The Road to the White House, 2000: The Politics of Presidential Elections* (New York: Palgrave, 2001), 212; Nelson Polsby and Aaron Wildavsky, *Presidential Elections: Strategies and Structures of American Politics*, 11th ed., (Lanham, MD: Rowman and Littlefield, 2004), 138–139.

¹³ See for example, Kathryn Dunn Tenpas, “Presidential Travel and the Permanent Campaign” (paper presented at The Brookings Institution, 29 March 2004), accessed at <http://www.brookings.edu/views/papers/tenpas/20040629.htm>, 12 April 2009.

FIGURE 2
Total Trips to Large and Small States, Compared



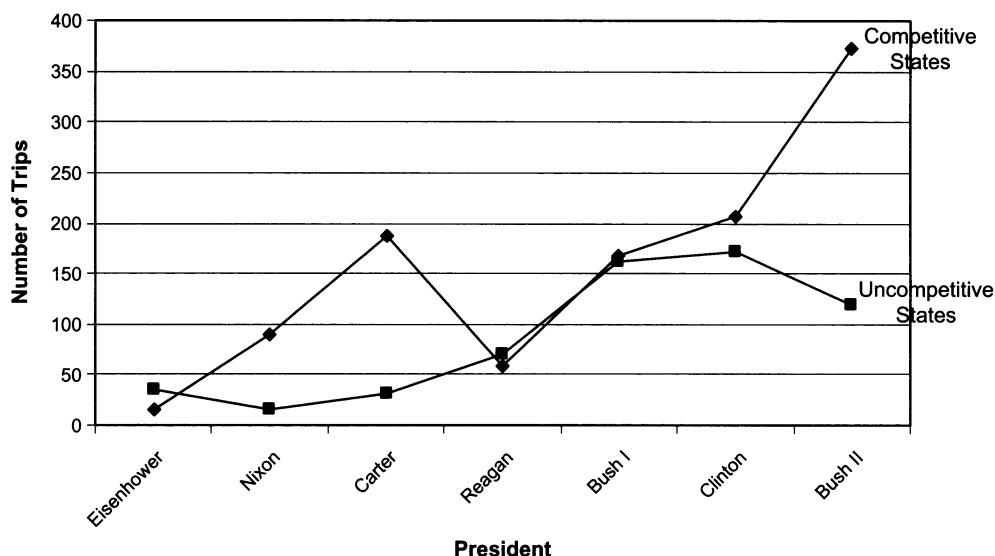
Source: Travel data drawn from *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*. Washington, DC: United States Government Printing Office.

states that are hotly contested, assuming that a personal visit to those states could have a tangible impact, while “safe” states will vote in a predictable manner, irrespective of candidate visits. The size of the state becomes less relevant, as even small states can present crucial electoral votes in a close contest.

In Figures 2 and 3, we break down the states based on their size and the level of political competition. As shown in the second figure, all presidents from Eisenhower to George W. Bush traveled more often to electoral vote-rich states. To illustrate, we compare states with 20 or more electoral votes to those with only 5 or fewer. Over this 40-year period, we find a growing tendency for the president to prefer states with more electoral college votes. Eisenhower did not travel nearly as much as his successors, but when he did, he was slightly more inclined to visit a large state. During the George W. Bush term, the gap between states with many votes versus those with only a few is striking; the president was nearly five times more likely to visit the larger states.

Yet as Figure 3 suggests, presidential travel has also been conditioned by the nature of political competition within a state. In states where the president fared very well in the previous election, or where he lost by a significant margin,

FIGURE 3
Total Trips to Competitive and Uncompetitive States, Compared



Source: Travel data drawn from *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*. Washington, DC: United States Government Printing Office.

we would expect fewer visits. For several presidents, this is what we find. In this figure, we define a “competitive” state as one that the president won or lost by a margin of three percentage points; “uncompetitive” states are those where this margin rose to eight or more points. To make this measure of competitiveness comparable across presidencies, we calculate margins of victory or loss only with respect to the two-party vote; omitted from the tally are votes cast for third-party or independent candidates. After the 1968, 1980, and 1992 elections, the president and his advisers no doubt spent hours poring over the rather large tallies in some states for George Wallace (1968), John Anderson (1980), and Ross Perot (1992). It is entirely possible that support for independent and third-party candidates had an effect on traveling decisions for Nixon, Reagan, and Clinton. We think it likely, however, that the relative split between Democratic and Republican voters would be far more salient when deciding where to visit.

The evidence suggests that President George W. Bush adopted a highly strategic travel schedule, visiting the most electorally competitive states throughout his first term. However, the choice of the “battleground” strategy may also reflect the circumstances of the initial election—contrast President George W. Bush with President Ronald Reagan. Reagan’s low overall trip taking has already been discussed, but may have been justified by more than media skills

alone. Reagan's presidential victory in 1980 was constructed with massive individual state victories: he won 31 states by margins of 10 percent or more over his closest competitor, accounting for 341 electoral votes. President Reagan faced an electoral context lacking real competitive states and could easily win reelection through consolidation. In addition, challenger quality can have a major impact on incumbent strategy—for example, Reagan's 1984 opponent, Walter Mondale, was not considered to be a formidable threat, further diminishing the prospect of a Reagan defeat.

On the other hand, facing off against a weak opponent in an *initial* election can prove dangerous for the incumbent, producing a false sense of security and lethargic reelection planning. President George H.W. Bush, who won his initial election in 1988 against a “weak” opponent, Michael Dukakis, faced a much stronger challenge for reelection in the form of Bill Clinton, one for which he was unprepared. The candidacy of President Bush was also imperiled by the rapid decline of his once-record-high approval ratings that began to dip in May of 1991. Figure 3 reveals this predicament as President George H.W. Bush ended up spending nearly equal time in competitive and uncompetitive states during the heat of the campaign, suggesting that he had squandered his margin of support in what were once deemed uncompetitive states, thereby necessitating additional presidential attention.

Unlike Reagan and the elder President Bush, then-Governor George W. Bush gained the presidency in historically contested circumstances, constructing a victory on a precarious basis of swing states and a favorable opinion from the U.S. Supreme Court, suggesting that swing-state considerations would figure prominently in his reelection efforts. Below, we delve into these inferences more formally, taking into account the three variables covered in Figures 1 through 3 and Table 1: state-level political competition; the number of electoral votes cast by a state; and the passage of time in the presidents' first terms.

SUMMARY REGRESSION METHODS AND FINDINGS

We turn our attention here to summary models of presidential travel. At least since Nixon, presidents have tended to target states that produce more electoral votes. That public officials would budget their time so as to maximize their chance of success in the next round of elections is hardly surprising, though we know far more about members of Congress than presidents in this regard.¹⁴ To gauge the strategic element of presidential traveling more formally, we estimate the following model:

Number of trips to a state = $\alpha + \beta_1$ (electoral votes) + β_2 (absolute margin of victory or loss in the state in the previous election) + β_3 (electoral votes $\times$

¹⁴ See Glenn R. Parker and Suzanne L. Parker, “Correlates and Effects of Attention to District by U.S. House Members,” *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 10 (May 1985): 223–242.

absolute margin of victory or loss) + β_{4-6} (year of the presidential term, dummy coded) + β_{7-9} (year $\times$ electoral votes) + β_{10-12} (year $\times$ absolute margin of victory or loss) + β_{13-15} (year $\times$ absolute margin $\times$ electoral votes) + β_{16} (home state) + β_{17} (Virginia) + β_{18} (Maryland) + ϵ .

We would expect that, all other things equal, the sign for β_1 would be positive; the larger a state's weight in the electoral college, the more often a president would visit. If chief executives are prompted to act strategically based on electoral concerns, however, they must also take into account their potential popularity come the next election. It might do little good to land in Air Force One and enjoy all of the free publicity that comes with a presidential visit if the chosen state is destined to fall into the opposition camp. By the same logic, presidents seeking to maximize their reelection chances may have little incentive to visit states that they are nearly certain to win.

Of course, no political actors—not even presidents—have a crystal ball to predict with certainty how a state will vote in the next election. When considering whether a state is competitive, however, reasonable inferences can be drawn based on past outcomes.¹⁵ Executives who won or lost a state decisively might understandably avoid traveling to it, at least as part of an electoral strategy. In the regression model, the β_2 parameter is meant to capture this behavior; as the absolute margin of victory or loss for a president within a particular state rises (based, as earlier, on only the two-party vote), we would expect to observe fewer visits. The β_{4-6} terms are included to take into account the year of the presidential terms (second, third, or fourth year, with the first year serving as the excluded baseline category). All other things equal, the demands of the public presidency would likely increase over the course of an administration as international obligations and efforts to mobilize support for the presidential agenda increase, necessitating more travel away from the confines of the White House. If presidential governing is being replaced, however, by more of a permanent campaign for support, the impact of these temporal dummies could be weaker for the more recent presidential administrations.¹⁶

We further anticipate the possibility of several interaction effects. The first of these (β_3) combines the size of a state *and* its competitiveness. When scheduling visits, a president thinking solely in strategic electoral terms would travel to larger states that are in play. Smaller states that may be competitive would be less-desirable destinations, as would larger states where the president won or lost by a wide margin in the preceding contest. The other interaction terms (β_{7-9} , β_{10-12} , and β_{13-15}) allow for the effects of electoral votes, margin of victory or defeat, and the combination of the two factors to vary from one year to the next.

¹⁵ On this point, see George Rabinowitz and Stuart Elaine MacDonald, "The Power of the States in U.S. Presidential Elections," *American Political Science Review* 80 (March 1986): 72–73.

¹⁶ Blumenthal, *Permanent Campaign*. See also Heclo, "Campaigning and Governing."

The final three predictors in the model control for the president's officially recognized home state—a common vacation destination—and the two states bordering Washington, DC, Virginia, and Maryland. (President Clinton, having been Governor of Arkansas prior to his presidency, did not own a house in his home state. He did make several trips to the houses of personal friends for vacations, and these are excluded from the data set by virtue of being visits to private homes. Dwight Eisenhower's preference for spending much of the summer in Colorado does lead to a higher number of public appearances there, in comparison to many other states, particularly in 1954.) Adding these dummies to the model effectively omits these states from the analysis. The last element of the model, ϵ , represents travel that cannot be clearly linked to electoral considerations. This term surely touches on a large number of trips, since an electoral college–based rationale is but one strategy that might shape a president's schedule. When campaigning for reelection, presidents might also increase their travel to states where more members of key interest groups can be found, more funds can be raised, or more national media attention can be gained. Such factors fall beyond the scope of this model. Political or personal conditions that would prevent a president from leaving the DC area (e.g., Ronald Reagan's hospitalization following an assassination attempt) are also relegated to the ϵ term.

Since the dependent variable is a count of trips, and therefore bounded by zero, ordinary least-squares regression would be inappropriate. We estimate these effects instead through negative binomial regression.¹⁷ The coefficients for each presidential term appear in Appendix A. Because interaction terms can be notoriously difficult to interpret—especially when based on three components (electoral votes, competitiveness, and year in the term)—and negative binomial regressions, on the whole, lack the transparency of more common OLS (ordinary least squares) models, we will not focus our attention on the slope estimates themselves. Rather, to assess the interplay of electoral considerations and time at a grounded, tangible level, we use the regression parameters from the Appendix to simulate traveling preferences under three different choice scenarios: visits to “big, competitive” states versus “*small, uncompetitive*” states; “big, competitive” states versus “*small, competitive*” states; and “big, competitive” states versus “big, *uncompetitive*” states. CLARIFY software was used to assess these differences.¹⁸

The forecasts in Appendix B are offered solely for heuristic purposes. We are not attempting to explain why a president chose to visit, say, Pennsylvania

¹⁷ Gary King, *Unifying Political Methodology* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1989).

¹⁸ Michael Tomz, Jason Wittenberg, and Gary King, “CLARIFY: Software for Interpreting and Presenting Statistical Results, Version 2.0,” Cambridge, MA: Harvard University, 1 June 2001, accessed at <http://gking.harvard.edu>, 12 April 2009; and Gary King, Michael Tomz, and Jason Wittenberg, “Making the Most of Statistical Analyses: Improving Interpretation and Presentation,” *American Journal of Political Science* 44 (April 2000): 347–361.

or Indiana. The rather low “pseudo- R^2 s” in the regressions in the Appendix (ranging from 0.082 to 0.260) suggest that there is a great deal of variation in trip taking—whether to Pennsylvania, Indiana, or any other state—that has not been modeled. Yet, through these simulations, we can identify underlying salient factors that prompted a president to select a bigger and more-competitive state over the others, and at what point in the term such distinctions became more relevant. For our purposes, we define a big state as one that possesses 20 electoral votes; and a state is said to be competitive if the margin of victory or loss in the previous election was 3 percent, based on the two-party vote. A small state is one that contributes only five votes to the electoral college tally; and an uncompetitive state is one that was won or lost by a margin of eight points.

At the top of Appendix B, we see that for all presidents in each part of the term, there was indeed a tendency to visit large and more competitive states more often than smaller, less-competitive states. In the Eisenhower and Nixon years, these differences were, however, rather small. In the first year of the Eisenhower administration, for example, the predicted number of trips to a hypothetical “large and competitive” state exceeds visits to the “small and less competitive” state only by an average of .37. This difference is statistically significant ($p < .05$), but in substantive terms it would be difficult to argue that the president was following an “Electoral College” strategy at that moment. Moreover, in his second and third years, President Eisenhower did not travel to larger and more competitive states significantly more often than to small, uncompetitive states. In his first four years in office, President Nixon preferred visiting larger and more competitive states more frequently vis-à-vis states that were small and uncompetitive. Yet according to the regression model, the differences in average trips, while statistically significant, are not large (.43, .65, .71, and .67). This tendency for Eisenhower and Nixon to engage in less strategic travel fits with what others have observed about the two presidencies. For health reasons, Eisenhower played less of a public role, and Nixon is said to have favored a “Rose Garden” strategy for reaching out to the public.¹⁹

For presidents who served after Nixon (Carter to Bush II), we observe an increasing tendency to target larger and more politically competitive states at the expense of smaller, less competitive areas, with the greatest difference surfacing in the fourth year. This pattern is especially apparent for Presidents Clinton and G.W. Bush. Indeed, in the final year of his first term, George W. Bush is estimated to have taken an average of 10 additional trips to the hypothetical “large, competitive state” compared to a smaller and less competitive state — a magnitude that dwarfs the differences calculated for the other chief executives.

In the middle of Appendix B, we find complementary evidence that presidents prefer to travel to the prototypical “big, competitive” state more

¹⁹ Lammers, “Presidential Attention-Focusing Activities,” 146.

than to the “small, but competitive” state. Again, only in the case of President Eisenhower does this difference in trip-taking fail to reach statistical significance consistently. Furthermore, this inclination to target “big, competitive” states at the expense of “smaller but competitive” places also becomes more pronounced over time, save for the case of Eisenhower. For Presidents Carter through Bush II, we see dramatic increases during the fourth year in predicted average visits to “big, competitive” states as opposed to “small, competitive” locations. Jimmy Carter, for example, took approximately 4 more trips to larger and more competitive states compared to those that were smaller but still competitive in the year of his reelection bid. This difference is over five times as large as that calculated for the preceding year (0.77).

Finally, at the bottom of Appendix B, we find that there was much less differentiation from Eisenhower to G.H.W. Bush in tendencies to visit “big, competitive” versus “big, but uncompetitive” states. In fact, through much of his term, Reagan was significantly more likely to travel to the hypothetical “big, uncompetitive” state, again reflecting his safe electoral context. Clearly between Eisenhower and the first President Bush, presidents were inclined to visit states with a large number of electoral votes even if they had not decisively won or lost them in the preceding election. Strategizing based on electoral vote calculations had its limits.

Yet as shown in this table, this pattern changed under Clinton and G.W. Bush. Bill Clinton became significantly more likely to travel to a “big, competitive” state rather than one that was “big, but uncompetitive” in his fourth year, and this feature of presidential travel carried over into all four years of the Bush II term. It is worth noting as well that Bush’s tendency to visit larger competitive states more often than those that were just as large but uncompetitive grew markedly over the course of the term. In the first year, the trip count differential was 1.15. By the end of the term, this difference increases to 8.31, a truly noteworthy rise in strategic travel.

We suspect that this newfound preference to target larger, more competitive states at the expense of less-competitive areas is an outgrowth of the hardening of state-level partisan blocs. In a recent piece on political polarization within the United States, Alan Abramowitz and Kyle Sanders point to increasingly deep and reliable divisions between Democratic and Republican states, the so-called “Blue” and “Red” regions of the country. Prior to the 1990s, this Blue/Red distinction would not have been as clear-cut.²⁰ Presidents Nixon

²⁰ Alan Abramowitz and Kyle Sanders, “Why Can’t We All Just Get Along? The Reality of a Polarized America,” *The Forum* 3 (July 2005), accessed at <http://www.bepress.com/forum/vol3/iss2/>, 11 April 2009. On the increasing homogeneity of counties, states, and regions with respect to partisan voting, see also Jeongdae Kim, Euel Elliott, and Ding-Ming Wang, “A Spatial Analysis of County-Level Outcomes in U.S. Presidential Elections: 1988-2000,” *Electoral Studies* 22 (December 2003): 741–761, and David C. Kimball, “A Decline in Ticket Splitting and the Increasing Salience of Party Labels” in H.F. Weisberg and C. Wilcox, eds., *Models of Voting in Presidential Elections: The 2000 Elections* (Palo Alto, CA: Stanford University Press, 2003), 161–179.

through Bush I, all of whom were apparently sensitive to electoral college incentives with respect to visiting large-versus-small states, would have been somewhat less able to predict the future partisan dispositions of the larger states based on the results from the previous election. Consequently, there would have been less reason to take past competitiveness into account when scheduling trips.

Given that the small-versus-large distinction appears to have been more consistently meaningful to presidents than differences in state-level partisan competitiveness (at least since Eisenhower), we estimated an alternative set of regression models built on the assumption that state population size—not prior partisan disposition or the number of electoral votes within the state—predicted presidential visits. These models underperformed those presented in Appendix B, especially for Presidents Reagan, Clinton, and G.W. Bush. This holds true as well for models based on population density within a state. In general, then, when presidents set their traveling schedules, the incentives of the electoral college seem to matter more than the opportunity simply to come into contact with larger numbers of voters.

CONCLUSION

It should come as no surprise that presidents are strategic actors. Do we not expect government officials to further their self-interests, and respond as rationally as possible to electoral college-based incentives?²¹ Nevertheless, the notion of the strategic presidency is fortified by this analysis of first-term presidential travel. Indeed, the results uncovered here point to the gradual emergence of a *hyper-public* presidency. A presidential visit is a valuable commodity, one that presidents are increasingly deploying for electoral purposes. Many of the trips a president takes (e.g., visits to flood-ravaged New Orleans or to New York City after September 11) could not be linked easily and directly to electoral considerations. Yet, our analysis strongly indicates that presidents respond to election-based incentives, and that these tendencies have grown significantly since the Eisenhower years.

Previous studies have charted the growth of the public presidency, stressing how changes in the party system, candidate nomination rules, and the Washington policymaking environment have encouraged chief executives to reach out to the electorate in the most personal of terms.²² Travel is now an integral part of presidential governing, a facet of executive leadership that

²¹ David Mayhew, *The Electoral Connection* (New Haven, CT: Yale University, 1974).

²² See Lowi, *The Personal President*; Richard Waterman, "Closing the Expectations Gap: The Presidential Search for New Political Resources" in Richard W. Waterman, ed., *The Presidency Reconsidered* (Itasca, IL: F.E. Peacock Publishers, 1993), 23–46; Sidney M. Milkis, *The President and the Parties: The Transformation of the American Party System since the New Deal* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993); and Tenpas, *Presidents as Candidates*.

researchers are only beginning to understand. What other factors beyond electoral considerations prompt presidents to leave the White House? What specific activities do they take part in on their travels? And how do these trips affect the president's standing in the polls? Having documented the electoral calculus underlying traveling decisions, we plan to examine these questions in our future work.

From the standpoint of presidential representation and responsiveness to national concerns, our results are somewhat troubling. Many political scientists and news commentators have criticized the electoral college system for injecting a measure of arbitrariness into electoral politics: it is certainly possible for a second-place finisher in the popular vote to win in the electoral college (witness the contest in 2000); American voters do not select the president, only slates of electors who have no formal obligation, only an ethical obligation, to follow the wishes of citizens in their states; and voters living outside of key battleground states may have less access to information about the campaigns, and consequently may be less likely to participate.²³ To these concerns, we add another. Well before the formal start of a general election campaign and Election Day itself, the electoral college shapes the president's scheduling and the public face of the executive branch. Some areas of the country—in particular, larger states that are not firmly in one partisan camp or another—enjoy greater access to the president and to the benefits that such visits can bring.*

²³ See Demetrios James Caraley, "Editor's Opinion: Why Americans Need a Constitutional Right to Vote for Presidential Electors," *Political Science Quarterly* 116 (Spring 2001): 1–3; Jennifer Wolak, "The Consequences of Presidential Battleground Strategies for Citizen Engagement," *Political Research Quarterly* 59 (September 2006): 353–361; and David Hill and Seth C. McKee, "The Electoral College, Mobilization, and Turnout in the 2000 Presidential Election," *American Politics Research* 33 (September 2005): 700–725.

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APPENDIX A
Negative Binomial Regression Models of Presidential Travel: Coefficients, with Standards Errors in Parentheses

	Eisenhower	Nixon	Carter	Reagan	Bush I	Clinton	Bush II
Electoral votes (EV)	0.106 (0.067)	0.098 (0.033)	0.035 (0.026)	0.092 (0.026)	0.054 (0.022)	0.044 (0.034)	0.049 (0.023)
Absolute margin (AM)	0.098 (0.087)	0.001 (0.128)	-0.111 (0.125)	-0.004 (0.063)	-0.012 (0.067)	-0.020 (0.073)	-0.094 (0.025)
EV × AM	-0.007 (0.010)	-0.011 (0.012)	0.012 (0.012)	0.006 (0.003)	0.003 (0.004)	0.003 (0.004)	0.0004 (0.0028)
Year 2 of term	1.86 (1.17)	1.11 (0.779)	0.697 (0.647)	1.14 (0.816)	0.276 (0.631)	-0.474 (0.730)	0.840 (0.458)
Year 3 of term	-0.162 (1.24)	0.773 (0.793)	1.33 (0.643)	1.97 (0.814)	0.800 (0.658)	0.048 (0.716)	-0.026 (0.493)
Year 4 of term	1.68 (1.24)	-0.264 (0.871)	0.975 (0.646)	2.70 (0.752)	1.16 (0.612)	1.75 (0.633)	1.88 (0.462)
Year 2 × EV	-0.085 (0.087)	-0.022 (0.037)	-0.0004 (0.0334)	-0.034 (0.034)	-0.003 (0.029)	0.059 (0.047)	-0.022 (0.031)
Year 3 × EV	0.024 (0.087)	-0.019 (0.037)	-0.028 (0.034)	-0.065 (0.036)	-0.032 (0.031)	0.019 (0.046)	0.014 (0.032)
Year 4 × EV	-0.072 (0.089)	0.022 (0.038)	0.039 (0.034)	-0.032 (0.030)	0.008 (0.032)	-0.007 (0.042)	-0.005 (0.030)
Year 2 × AM	-0.126 (0.120)	0.043 (0.143)	0.074 (.148)	0.036 (0.070)	0.001 (0.087)	0.086 (0.100)	-0.031 (0.058)
Year 3 × AM	0.095 (0.114)	0.043 (0.143)	-0.063 (0.162)	-0.069 (0.076)	-0.143 (0.100)	-0.036 (0.101)	-0.006 (0.064)
Year 4 × AM	-0.196 (0.137)	0.051 (0.157)	-0.036 (0.155)	-0.087 (0.072)	-0.005 (0.082)	-0.165 (0.093)	-0.269 (0.073)
Year 2 × EV × AM	0.010 (0.013)	-0.0005 (0.0139)	-0.004 (0.013)	0.001 (0.004)	0.002 (0.006)	-0.008 (0.006)	0.002 (0.004)
Year 3 × EV × AM	-0.010 (0.013)	0.004 (0.014)	-0.0004 (0.0146)	0.005 (0.004)	0.008 (0.006)	-0.002 (0.006)	-0.001 (0.004)
Year 4 × EV × AM	0.012 (0.014)	0.001 (0.014)	0.00002 (0.0137)	0.0007 (0.0035)	0.003 (0.006)	0.002 (0.006)	0.004 (0.004)
Constant	-2.65 (0.925)	-1.87 (0.692)	-1.20 (0.524)	-2.80 (0.700)	-0.752 (0.485)	-0.342 (.525)	0.461 (0.354)
Pseudo- R^2	0.082	0.211	0.174	0.260	0.187	0.177	0.242
χ^2 18	29.8	103.1	110.3	156.0	155.2	149.1	225.5

Note: Dummy predictors for Maryland, Virginia, and the president's home state were also included in each model. For economy of presentation, these coefficients and the over-dispersion parameter are not shown.

Source: Travel data drawn from *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*. Washington, DC: United States Government Printing Office.

APPENDIX B

Clarifying the Regression Results: The Emerging Preference to Visit "Big, Competitive" States at the Expense of Other States

Predicted difference in the average number of presidential trips to a *Big, Competitive State* versus trips to a...

i. *Small, Uncompetitive State*

	<u>First Year</u>	<u>Second Year</u>	<u>Third Year</u>	<u>Fourth Year</u>
Eisenhower	0.37*	0.35	0.31	0.56*
Nixon	0.43*	0.65**	0.71**	0.67**
Carter	0.69*	1.10*	1.12*	4.32**
Reagan	0.44**	0.63**	0.75**	2.74**
Bush I	0.99**	1.39**	1.48**	4.75**
Clinton	1.09**	2.25**	1.67**	5.22**
Bush II	2.33**	3.27**	3.02**	10.14**

ii. *Small, Competitive State*

	<u>First Year</u>	<u>Second Year</u>	<u>Third Year</u>	<u>Fourth Year</u>
Eisenhower	0.42*	0.29	0.41	0.42
Nixon	0.38**	0.60**	0.75**	0.68*
Carter	0.64**	1.14**	0.77*	4.01**
Reagan	0.45**	0.77**	0.71**	2.47**
Bush I	1.00**	1.44**	1.13**	4.84**
Clinton	1.06*	2.45**	1.46**	3.48**
Bush II	1.76**	1.97*	2.39**	6.32**

iii. *Big, Uncompetitive State*

	<u>First Year</u>	<u>Second Year</u>	<u>Third Year</u>	<u>Fourth Year</u>
Eisenhower	0.12	-0.13	0.32	-0.02
Nixon	0.29	0.65	0.30	0.30
Carter	-1.70	-2.81	-1.22	-5.20
Reagan	-0.44	-1.61**	-1.22**	-0.83
Bush I	-0.49	-1.30	-0.87	-4.43
Clinton	-0.31	0.54	0.45	2.69*
Bush II	1.15*	1.71*	1.70**	8.31**

Note: These differences in predicted presidential traveling preferences were derived from the negative binomial event count regression models in Appendix A. *CLARIFY* software was used to calculate these figures. For purposes of illustration: a "big" state is one with 20 electoral votes; a "small" state has 5 electoral votes; a state is said to be "competitive" if the margin of victory or loss in the previous election was 3 percent, based on the two-party vote; it is "uncompetitive" if this margin was 8 percent. "*" = the difference in predicted visits is statistically significant at the .05-level; "**" = the difference is significant at the .01-level.

Source: Travel data drawn from *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*. Washington, DC: United States Government Printing Office.